

The political divide

Let's Meet Up p. 238F

Days after Orlando attack, House G.O.P. blocks vote on gay-rights amendment

Less than three days after a popular gay club in Orlando became the site of the deadliest mass shooting in U.S. history, Republican leaders in the House of Representatives¹ blocked a vote on a proposal that would ensure federal contractors² can't discriminate against employees on the basis of sexual orientation or gender identification. Hours earlier, a number of notable conservative figures had put on a good show of standing in solidarity with the L.G.B.T. community, making the rounds on cable news to stand up for the dozens of gay men and women who died in Sunday's attack. On Tuesday night, however, it was back to business as usual as the House Rules Committee prevented the amendment from reaching the floor³ for a vote.

Democrat Sean Patrick Maloney, an openly gay congressman from New York, proposed the amendment, which is currently attached to a Defense Department spending bill⁴ that was slated for a vote⁵ this week. Should it pass, the proposal would enforce an executive order⁶ from 2010 prohibiting discrimination against L.G.B.T. employees, *The Hill* reports. "It's hard to imagine any act that is so horrific could lead to anything positive. But if we were going to do anything, it would be a very positive step to say that discrimination has no place in our law and to reaffirm the president's actions in this area," Maloney said.

The decision to block a vote on the Defense Department bill comes mere days after a lone gunman opened fire at Florida's Pulse nightclub, murdering 46 people before being shot and killed by police.

The shooting has since been labeled both a terrorist attack and a hate crime. Maloney told *The Hill* that passing the bill with the attached amendment would be a "pretty basic thing to do" to show support for the L.G.B.T. community targeted in the attack. [...] Maloney drew parallels between the Orlando massacre and the shooting at the Emanuel African Methodist Episcopal Church in Charleston, South Carolina, last year, which led to legislation that restricted how the Confederate flag can be displayed. "Hate has no place in our flags, in our workplace, or in our country," Maloney argued. "And it should have no place in federal law."

Abigail Tracy, *Vanity Fair*, 2016

1. Explain what happened in Orlando.
2. What was the aim of Maloney's proposed law?
3. How did Republicans react to what happened in Orlando? How does this compare to their vote on the new law?
4.  You are a gay rights activist. Say how you feel about the Republicans' vote.

¹House of representatives A part of the US Congress where new laws are voted

²contractors: government employees

³reaching the floor: being considered for discussion

⁴bill: a proposal for a new law

⁵slated for a vote: scheduled for a vote

⁶executive order: an official order from the president